

Word family: **button** / buttoned / buttoning / buttoned-up

Base word: button

Past tense: buttoned

Past participle: buttoned

Related forms: buttoning, buttoned-up

Useful extensions: mute button, mouse button, panic button, belly button, button-down, hot-button

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞) / adjective-related forms (相關形式)

Your sentence:

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute **button** on the outside world.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **button** means a **physical or digital control that you press to activate a particular function**.

Meaning: A small control that activates a machine, device, or function when pressed.

繁體中文: 按下後會啟動、停止或改變某項設備功能的小型控制鍵

中文翻譯:

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute button on the outside world.”

「那感覺就像有人替整個外界按下了靜音鍵一樣。」

mute button = 按下後把聲音關掉的靜音按鈕／靜音鍵

1. **button = machine/device control (機器／裝置控制鍵) — 按鈕; 控制鍵**

This is the meaning in your original sentence.

Meaning: A small control that you press in order to make a machine or device perform a function.

Practice 1 — Original

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute **button** on the outside world.”

「那感覺就像有人替整個外界按下了**靜音鍵**一樣。」

Practice 2

> “Press the red **button** to stop the machine.”

「按下紅色**按鈕**便可停止機器。」

Practice 3

> “I accidentally pressed the wrong **button**.”

「我不小心按錯了**控制鍵**。」

button = 按下後會啟動、停止或改變某項設備功能的小型控制裝置

2. **button** = digital/interface control (網站／應用程式介面) — 畫面上的按鈕; 功能鍵

The button does not have to be a physical object.

Meaning: A clickable or tappable control displayed on a computer, phone, website, or app.

Practice 4

> “Click the **button** at the bottom of the page.”

「點擊頁面底部的**功能按鈕**。」

Practice 5

> “Tap the ‘Save’ **button** when you finish.”

「完成後按一下畫面上的「Save」**按鈕**。」

button = 顯示在數碼介面上、點擊或觸碰後會執行某項功能的控制元素

I would treat #1 and #2 as branches of the **same core control meaning**:

* physical button → 用手實際按

* digital button → 在畫面上點擊／觸碰

3. **button** = mouse/controller control (滑鼠／控制器上的按鍵) — 按鍵

****Meaning:**** One of the controls on a mouse, game controller, remote control, etc.

Practice 6

> “Click the right mouse ****button****.”

「按一下滑鼠****右鍵****。」

Practice 7

> “Hold down this ****button**** to run.”

「按住這個****按鍵****便可以奔跑。」

****button = 滑鼠、遙控器或控制器上供使用者輸入指令的按鍵****

Again, semantically this belongs to the same broad ****control**** concept.

4. ****button = clothing fastener (衣物上的鈕扣) — 鈕扣; 衣扣****

This is the other major everyday meaning.

****Meaning:**** A small round or shaped object attached to clothing and passed through a hole to fasten the garment.

Practice 8

> “One of the ****buttons**** on my shirt is missing.”

「我襯衫上的一粒****鈕扣****不見了。」

Practice 9

> “The coat has six metal ****buttons****.”

「這件外套有六粒金屬****鈕扣****。」

****button = 縫在衣物上的小型扣件, 通常穿過扣眼來固定衣服****

5. ****button + clothing (衣服) — 扣上鈕扣****

Here, **button** is a verb.

Meaning: To fasten clothing using its buttons.

Practice 10

> “She **buttoned** her coat before going outside.”

「她出門前把外套的**鈕扣扣好**。」

Practice 11

> “He slowly **buttoned** his shirt.”

「他慢慢把襯衫的**鈕扣逐粒扣上**。」

button something = 利用衣物上的鈕扣把衣服扣好、固定起來

6. **buttoned** = clothing (衣物) fastened with buttons — 已扣上鈕扣的

Practice 12

> “His jacket was fully **buttoned**.”

「他的外套**鈕扣全部扣好了**。」

Practice 13

> “She wore the shirt **buttoned** to the neck.”

「她把襯衫的鈕扣**一直扣到領口**。」

buttoned = 衣物的鈕扣已經扣上、處於固定狀態的

7. **button** = small round badge (小型徽章) — 圓形徽章; 襟章

Especially common in American English.

Meaning: A small round badge, often carrying a slogan, logo, picture, or political/campaign message and pinned to clothing.

Practice 14

> “She wore a **button** with the charity’s logo.”

「她佩戴了一枚印有慈善機構標誌的**圓形襟章**。」

Practice 15

> “They handed out campaign **buttons** at the event.”

「他們在活動中派發競選**徽章／襟章**。」

button = 可別在衣服上、通常印有文字或圖案的小型圓形徽章

In British English, **badge** is usually the more natural general word.

8. **button** = small round part resembling a clothing button (形狀像鈕扣的小型圓形物) — 鈕扣狀的小物件／部分

Some compounds use **button** because something is small and round like a clothing button.

A very common example is:

belly button = navel — 肚臍

> “The baby’s **belly button** has healed.”

「寶寶的**肚臍**已經癒合。」

> “The scar is just below her **belly button**.”

「疤痕就在她的**肚臍**下方。」

belly button = 肚臍; 腹部中央原本連接臍帶的位置

This is a family extension, not a separate general meaning you can freely apply to other body parts.

9. **button mushroom** (食物) — 洋菇; 鈕扣菇

Another useful shape-based compound.

****Meaning:**** A common small cultivated mushroom with a rounded cap.

Practice 16

> “Add some sliced ****button mushrooms**** to the sauce.”

「在醬汁中加入一些切片的****洋菇／鈕扣菇****。」

Practice 17

> “She fried the ****button mushrooms**** with garlic.”

「她用蒜頭炒了****洋菇****。」

****button mushroom = 菌蓋小而圓、外形像鈕扣的一種常見食用蘑菇****

10. ****at the press/touch/push of a button — 只需按一下按鈕便能立即完成****

This is a very common fixed expression.

****Meaning:**** Something can be done extremely easily or automatically by activating a control.

Practice 18

> “You can open the blinds at the ****touch of a button****.”

「你只需****按一下按鈕****便可以打開百葉簾。」

Practice 19

> “The entire system can be shut down at the ****press of a button****.”

「整個系統只需****按一下按鈕****便可關閉。」

****at the touch/press of a button = 只需進行一個非常簡單的按鍵操作，便能立即啟動某項功能****

11. ****panic button (緊急求助控制) — 緊急按鈕; 警報按鈕****

****Meaning:**** A button used to quickly call for help, sound an alarm, or trigger an emergency response.

Practice 20

> “The receptionist has a **panic button** under the desk.”

「接待員的桌下設有一個**緊急求助按鈕**。」

Practice 21

> “Press the **panic button** if you are in immediate danger.”

「如果你面臨即時危險，便按下**緊急警報按鈕**。」

panic button = 在緊急或危險情況下，用來迅速發出警報或求助訊號的按鈕

12. **hot-button + issue/topic**(議題／話題) — 容易引起強烈爭議或情緒反應的

This is an important family extension.

Meaning: Describing a subject that attracts strong opinions, controversy, or emotional reactions.

Practice 22

> “Housing has become a **hot-button issue** in the city.”

「住屋已成為這座城市一個**很容易引起強烈意見和爭議的議題**。」

Practice 23

> “The speaker avoided several **hot-button topics**.”

「講者避開了幾個**容易引起激烈爭論的敏感話題**。」

hot-button issue = 很容易觸發強烈情緒、意見分歧或爭論的議題

Here, **button** is metaphorical: the topic is imagined as something that, when “pressed,” triggers a strong reaction.

13. **push/press someone's buttons**(人的情緒反應) — 刻意觸發某人的強烈情緒反應

This is a very common idiom and worth including under our family-extension rule.

****Meaning:**** To say or do something that you know will provoke a particular emotional response from someone, often annoyance or anger.

Practice 24

> “He knows exactly how to ****push my buttons****.”

「他很清楚怎樣****故意刺激我、觸發我的情緒反應****。」

Practice 25

> “Don’t let her comments ****push your buttons****.”

「不要讓她那些說話****輕易刺激到你的情緒****。」

****push someone’s buttons = 知道某人的敏感點, 並透過言行刻意觸發其強烈情緒****

This is figurative, based on the idea that people have imaginary “buttons” that trigger reactions.

14. ****button-down = shirt/collar (襯衫／領口) fastened with small buttons — 領尖可扣住的****

****Meaning:**** Describing a shirt or collar whose collar points are fastened to the shirt with buttons.

Practice 26

> “He wore a blue ****button-down**** shirt.”

「他穿了一件藍色的****領尖有鈕扣固定的襯衫****。」

Practice 27

> “A white ****button-down**** shirt works well for the office.”

「白色的****鈕扣領襯衫****很適合上班穿著。」

****button-down = 襯衫領尖可以用小鈕扣固定在衣身上的****

15. ****buttoned-up = person/style (人物／風格) very formal, restrained, or emotionally reserved — 拘謹正式的; 不輕易表露感情的****

This is a useful figurative extension.

****Meaning:**** Very formal, controlled, conventional, or unwilling to show emotions openly.

Practice 28

> “He seems quite ****buttoned-up**** at work.”

「他工作時顯得相當****拘謹正式**，不太表露個人情緒******。」

Practice 29

> “The company used to have a very ****buttoned-up**** culture.”

「這家公司以前的文化十分****保守拘謹、講究正式規矩****。」

****buttoned-up** = 像衣服完全扣好般，引申為舉止非常拘謹、正式或情感不外露的******

This is exactly the kind of useful family extension we should now flag.

Important distinction: ****button** vs **key**

They overlap in technology, but:

****button****

usually activates a function when pressed.

> “Press the power button.”

「按下電源按鈕。」

****key****

often refers specifically to one control on a keyboard or keypad.

> “Press the Enter key.”

「按 Enter 鍵。」

A keyboard has ****keys****, whereas a simple device often has ****buttons****.

Important distinction: **button vs switch**

button

Usually pressed, and may spring back immediately.

> “Press the button.”

switch

Often changes between stable states such as:

* on/off

* high/low

> “Turn the switch off.”

「把開關關掉。」

Modern devices can blur the distinction, but the physical designs differ.

Important distinction: **button vs icon**

On a digital interface:

button

= interactive control you click/tap to perform an action

icon

= small visual symbol representing an object, function, app, file, etc.

An **icon** may function as a button, but not every icon is necessarily a button.

Important distinction: **button vs badge**

button

In American English, can mean a small round pin badge.

badge

Broader:

- * name badge
- * police badge
- * achievement badge
- * identification badge

So:

every campaign button is a type of badge, but not every badge is a **button**.

Family-extension note

Following the updated Golden Manual, several expressions containing **button** deserve explicit inclusion because their meanings are highly useful:

- * **mute button** = 靜音鍵
- * **power button** = 電源按鈕
- * **mouse button** = 滑鼠按鍵
- * **panic button** = 緊急求助／警報按鈕
- * **belly button** = 肚臍
- * **button mushroom** = 洋菇／鈕扣菇
- * **button-down shirt** = 鈕扣領襯衫
- * **buttoned-up person/style** = 拘謹正式、不太表露感情的
- * **hot-button issue** = 容易引起強烈爭議的議題
- * **push someone's buttons** = 刻意刺激某人的情緒敏感點

These are not all separate meanings of bare **button**, but they are important members of the practical word family.

Master comparison

Form / sense MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning	
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button — physical control	按下後會啟動、停止或改變某項設備功能的小型控制裝置
button — digital interface	在網站或應用程式畫面上，點擊／觸碰後執行某項功能的控制元素

button — mouse/controller	滑鼠、遙控器或控制器上供使用者輸入指令的按鍵	
button — clothing	縫在衣物上並通常穿過扣眼來固定衣服的鈕扣	
button — verb	利用衣物上的鈕扣把衣服扣好、固定起來	
buttoned	鈕扣已扣上、衣物處於固定狀態的	
button — badge	可別在衣服上、通常印有圖案或文字的小型圓形襟章	
belly button	腹部中央原本連接臍帶的位置；肚臍	
button mushroom	菌蓋小而圓、外形似鈕扣的常見食用洋菇	
at the touch/press of a button	只需按一下控制鍵便能立即完成某項操作	
panic button	在危險或緊急情況下迅速發出警報／求助訊號的按鈕	
hot-button issue	很容易觸發強烈情緒、意見分歧或爭論的議題	
push someone's buttons	知道某人的敏感點並故意觸發其強烈情緒反應	
button-down	襯衫領尖可用小鈕扣固定在衣身上的	
buttoned-up	舉止非常拘謹、正式、保守或不輕易表露情緒的	

For your original sentence

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute ****button**** on the outside world.”

The exact meaning is:

****button = 按下後能啟動某項設備功能的小型控制鍵****

So:

****mute button = 按下後使聲音輸出停止的靜音按鈕／靜音鍵****

And metaphorically:

****the outside world had a mute button****

= ****作者把整個外界想像成一部可以控制的裝置，戴上降噪耳機就像按下它的「靜音鍵」，令外界的噪音突然不再突出。****